

Olympiad Test Paper — Social Science (Class 7)

Chapter 8: How the Land Becomes Sacred

Subject	Social Science (NCERT Class 7)
Chapter	8 — How the Land Becomes Sacred
Total Questions	60 (Multiple Choice, single correct)
Maximum Marks	240
Suggested Time	90 minutes

Marking scheme: +4 for each correct answer · -1 for each wrong answer · 0 if unattempted.

Instructions: Each question has four options (A), (B), (C), (D); exactly one is correct. Watch the classic traps: sacredness in India is NOT limited to buildings - journeys, rivers, mountains, forests, trees and the whole land can be sacred; pilgrimage and trade routes often OVERLAPPED rather than being separate; many holy sites are SHARED across faiths; sacred groves are protected mainly by BELIEF, not government law; and the Kumbh Mela ROTATES among four cities on a roughly 12-year sky-based cycle, not the same place every year. Keep the char dham (4), jyotirlingas (12) and Shakti pithas (51) straight. Do not write on this paper — mark answers on your answer sheet.

1. In this chapter, something 'sacred' is best described as:

- (A) simply very old and made of stone
- (B) owned and run by the government
- (C) the largest building in a town
- (D) holy or divine, worthy of deep reverence and spiritual significance

2. The chapter's central new idea about sacredness in India is that it:

- (A) applies only to temples and mosques
- (B) belongs only to the oldest religion
- (C) can exist only inside cities
- (D) extends beyond buildings to journeys, rivers, mountains, forests, trees and even the whole land

3. To say India has a 'sacred geography' means that:

- (A) only one mountain in India is holy
- (B) holy places are spread across the land so that the territory itself feels sacred
- (C) geography lessons are taught inside temples
- (D) India has no maps of its holy sites

4. A 'pilgrimage' is:

- (A) a tax paid to a temple
- (B) a market held beside a river
- (C) a royal coronation ceremony
- (D) a journey to a sacred place significant within a religion

5. The Sanskrit word 'tirtha' literally means a:

- (A) mountain peak that touches the sky
- (B) pot that contains nectar
- (C) place to cross a river - symbolically, a crossing from ordinary to higher life
- (D) grove protected by a village

6. The fact that 'tirtha' (a sacred site) comes from a word for a river-crossing best suggests that:

- (A) sacred places were often imagined as points of crossing to a higher life
- (B) all sacred places must lie deep underwater
- (C) rivers were never considered holy
- (D) pilgrims were forbidden to cross rivers

7. A 'shrine' is a place regarded as holy because of its association with:

- (A) a famous battle and nothing else
- (B) a market town and nothing else
- (C) a royal palace and nothing else
- (D) the divine, a sacred relic, or a spiritual figure

8. A 'relic', as the chapter uses it, is:

- (A) a counted calendar era
- (B) a tax-free village grant
- (C) a confluence of two rivers
- (D) a part of a holy figure's body or one of their belongings, kept as an object of reverence

9. Which statement about religions and sacred places in India is correct?

- (A) only Hinduism has sacred places in India
- (B) only religions born in India have sacred sites here
- (C) almost every religion in India, whether born here or from outside, marks its own sacred places
- (D) sacred places exist only for religions that came from outside

10. Which group of religions ORIGINATED in India?

- (A) Islam, Christianity, Judaism and Zoroastrianism
- (B) Christianity, Sikhism, Judaism and Islam
- (C) Zoroastrianism, Hinduism, Islam and Buddhism
- (D) Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism and Sikhism

11. That Sufi dargahs draw devotees of several faiths shows that many of India's holy places are:

- (A) open to only one religion each
- (B) closed to everyone but kings
- (C) shared across religions and communities
- (D) located only outside India

- 12.** The idea that 'each sacred site in India belongs to only one religion' is:
(A) correct, since sharing a site is forbidden
(B) mistaken, because many sites are revered by people of several faiths
(C) correct, because only temples can be sacred
(D) mistaken, because no site is sacred to anyone
- 13.** Natural places such as rivers, mountains and groves are described as sacred:
(A) only to people living abroad (B) only after a government declares them so
(C) across many religions and communities, not just one
(D) only for a single year at a time
- 14.** The chapter stresses that pilgrimage in India is:
(A) a recent custom begun in modern times
(B) something practised only once in all of history
(C) an ancient tradition that has continued for thousands of years
(D) borrowed entirely from Europe
- 15.** Many important shrines sit on hilltops, making the journey hard. The chapter reads this difficulty as:
(A) an accident with no meaning (B) proof that the gods dislike visitors
(C) a way to keep all pilgrims away
(D) mirroring an inner, spiritual path the pilgrim travels
- 16.** A difficult hilltop pilgrimage is meaningful mainly because:
(A) it proves the pilgrim is physically the strongest
(B) it is the fastest possible way to reach a shrine
(C) the effort of the outer journey reflects the effort of inner spiritual growth
(D) it avoids any contact with Nature
- 17.** In Jainism, a 'Tirthankara' is:
(A) a river that two streams form
(B) a supreme preacher of dharma - literally 'one who makes a tirtha'
(C) a king who grants tax-free land (D) a giant fig tree
- 18.** Jain tirthas are especially linked to the:
(A) 12 jyotirlingas of Shiva (B) Tirthankaras, their supreme teachers
(C) 51 Shakti pithas of the goddess (D) Kumbh Mela cycle
- 19.** The shared root of 'tirtha' and 'Tirthankara' shows that, across Indian faiths, sacredness is often tied to:
(A) the idea of crossing from ordinary life to a higher, spiritual one
(B) paying money to a king (C) winning a war
(D) building the tallest tower

20. The 'char dham' are the four holy abodes that:

- (A) all stand in a single northern valley
- (B) ring India at its north, west, east and south
- (C) lie entirely outside India
- (D) are four shrines in one city

21. Which set correctly names the four char dham?

- (A) Badrinath, Dwarka, Puri and Rameswaram
- (B) Haridwar, Prayagraj, Nashik and Ujjain
- (C) Badrinath, Kanchipuram, Madurai and Dwarka
- (D) Puri, Bodh Gaya, Sarnath and Ujjain

22. The jyotirlingas are a network of how many sacred shrines, and to which deity?

- (A) 51 shrines dedicated to the goddess
- (B) 4 shrines dedicated to Vishnu
- (C) 7 shrines dedicated to the Buddha
- (D) 12 shrines dedicated to Shiva

23. The 51 Shakti pithas are, by tradition, the places where:

- (A) the Buddha preached his first sermon
- (B) the char dham were built
- (C) body parts of the divine mother (Sati) are said to have fallen
- (D) the Kumbh Mela is always held

24. Spreading the jyotirlingas and Shakti pithas right across the subcontinent had the effect of:

- (A) keeping each region completely isolated
- (B) tying distant regions together into one sacred landscape
- (C) limiting worship to one city
- (D) ending all pilgrimage

25. The deliberate scattering of sacred sites in nationwide networks best supports the idea that they were meant to:

- (A) link the whole subcontinent through shared sacred journeys
- (B) mark the borders of a single kingdom
- (C) be visited only by kings
- (D) replace all rivers with shrines

26. For at least 3,000 years, India's sacred geography helped to:

- (A) keep its regions permanently at war
- (B) knit together its many languages and customs into one civilisation
- (C) erase all local customs
- (D) prevent any travel between regions

27. How did sacred geography help integrate India, according to the chapter?

- (A) pilgrims travelling between far-flung sites carried ideas and customs across regions
- (B) it forced everyone to speak one single language
- (C) it sealed each region off from the others
- (D) it abolished all regional kingdoms

28. The chapter treats sacred geography mainly as a force that:

- (A) divided India into hostile faiths
- (B) mattered only to traders
- (C) existed only in modern times

(D) unified a diverse subcontinent over a very long time

29. The chapter corrects the idea that pilgrimage and trade were separate by showing that:

(A) traders were banned from all sacred sites

(B) pilgrimage routes and trade routes often overlapped, carrying both devotion and goods

(C) pilgrims never bought anything on the way (D) the two never used the same roads

30. Why would busy pilgrimage routes naturally attract traders?

(A) pilgrims were forbidden to carry any money

(B) sacred sites paid traders to stay away (C) trade was illegal everywhere in India

(D) large numbers of travelling pilgrims needed food, supplies and lodging

31. The overlap of pilgrimage and trade routes is a good example of how:

(A) religion and the economy never touched (B) only kings were allowed to travel

(C) religious life and economic life were closely woven together

(D) rivers blocked all movement

32. A 'sangam' is:

(A) a hilltop shrine reached by a hard climb (B) a giant banyan tree

(C) the confluence where two or more rivers meet, seen as an especially sacred crossing place

(D) a four-cornered pilgrim network

33. Rivers and their confluences have been worshipped in India since:

(A) only the last hundred years

(B) only after the Guptas fell

(C) only in modern cities

(D) at least Vedic times

34. Why are river confluences (sangams) regarded as especially sacred?

(A) because rivers there stop flowing forever

(B) as 'crossing places' where waters meet, they fit the deep idea of a tirtha

(C) because no one is allowed to bathe there

(D) because they mark a kingdom's tax border

35. The Kumbh Mela is best described as a:

(A) single hilltop shrine

(B) vast riverbank pilgrimage-fair held on a sacred calendar

(C) tax-free village grant

(D) Jain Tirthankara

36. The name 'Kumbh Mela' (kumbh + mela) refers to a:

(A) 'pot' and a 'gathering or fair', recalling the pot of amrita (nectar)

(B) 'mountain' and a 'river'

(C) 'king' and a 'temple'

(D) 'tree' and a 'grove'

37. Where is the Kumbh Mela held?

- (A) it rotates among Haridwar, Prayagraj, Nashik and Ujjain
- (B) at Badrinath, Dwarka, Puri and Rameswaram
- (C) always at the same single city (D) only at sites outside India

38. The timing and place of the Kumbh Mela are fixed by:

- (A) a vote of the local kings each year
- (B) the positions of Jupiter and the Sun on a roughly 12-year cycle
- (C) the first rainfall of the monsoon (D) the building of a new temple

39. Saying 'the Kumbh Mela is held at the same place every single year' is wrong because it:

- (A) actually rotates among four cities on a roughly 12-year sky-based cycle
- (B) is held in a different country each year
- (C) happens only once in a thousand years
- (D) is never actually held at all

40. Sacred mountains are often described in the chapter as:

- (A) borders that no one may approach (B) the only sacred places in all India
- (C) gateways to heaven (D) homes reserved for traders

41. The reverence for sacred mountains, rivers and forests reflects a worldview that:

- (A) treats Nature as worthless (B) keeps people away from all natural places
- (C) values only man-made buildings
- (D) protects Nature by treating the landscape as holy

42. Treating a mountain as a 'gateway to heaven' is an example of how, in India:

- (A) geography and religion are kept strictly apart
- (B) only flat land can be sacred (C) mountains are seen as worthless rock
- (D) geography, culture and spirituality fuse together

43. The 'peepal' is:

- (A) a confluence of rivers
- (B) a sacred fig tree (*Ficus religiosa*) revered across Indian faiths
- (C) a hilltop Jain shrine (D) a pot of nectar

44. The 'Bodhi tree', under which the Buddha is said to have attained enlightenment, was a:

- (A) banyan tree (B) mango tree
- (C) peepal tree (D) confluence of rivers

45. The banyan tree gets its English name from the:

- (A) 'banias' (traders) who gathered in its shade
- (B) kings who were crowned beneath it
- (C) rivers that flow past it (D) Tirthankaras who slept under it

46. The banyan (*Ficus benghalensis*) is distinctive because its:

- (A) leaves turn to gold each spring
- (B) hanging roots grow down and become new trunks
- (C) trunk is made of stone
- (D) flowers bloom only during the Kumbh

47. The great epics are said to scatter shrines across the land because they:

- (A) forbid pilgrimage to any site
- (B) name only one holy place in all of India
- (C) link many places to the journeys and deeds of their heroes, making those places sacred
- (D) describe no places at all

48. A 'sacred grove' is:

- (A) a natural forest a community protects as the abode of a deity
- (B) a planted royal garden taxed by the king
- (C) a market square in a city
- (D) a confluence of two rivers

49. In a sacred grove, activities such as hunting, felling trees and mining are:

- (A) encouraged in order to earn money
- (B) required to be done once a year
- (C) forbidden, because the grove is seen as a deity's home
- (D) allowed only to traders

50. Sacred groves are protected mainly by:

- (A) strict government laws and police patrols
- (B) high walls and locked gates
- (C) community belief that harming them disrespects a deity
- (D) regular payments from the king

51. The long survival of sacred groves shows that belief can:

- (A) only ever harm the environment
- (B) conserve biodiversity and water even without formal laws
- (C) work solely when backed by the police
- (D) protect buildings but never forests

52. The idea that 'sacred groves are protected by government laws' is:

- (A) largely mistaken; they are protected mainly by community belief
- (B) completely correct, since belief plays no part
- (C) correct, because groves are not really protected at all
- (D) mistaken, because such groves do not exist

53. The chapter notes that sacred geography:

- (A) is found only in India and nowhere else
- (B) was invented in modern Europe
- (C) applies only to deserts
- (D) exists in other parts of the world too, not only in India

54. 'Conservation', linked to sacred places, means:

- (A) cutting down forests for quick profit
- (B) building over rivers and confluences
- (C) protecting and keeping Nature, biodiversity or heritage safe for the future

(D) ignoring all old traditions

55. Treating land, rivers and forests as sacred is valuable for conservation today because it:

- (A) gives people a strong reason to protect Nature
- (B) makes Nature worthless in people's eyes
- (C) encourages the mining of every grove
- (D) proves that Nature cannot be harmed

56. The duty to conserve sacred places today follows from the chapter's view that they are:

- (A) a shared heritage of Nature and culture worth protecting
- (B) useless relics of the past
- (C) the property of traders alone
- (D) important only for tourism income

57. The big idea 'how the land becomes sacred' is best summed up as:

- (A) only a single temple in India is truly holy
- (B) land becomes sacred only when a king declares it so
- (C) sacredness has nothing to do with geography
- (D) through pilgrimage, networks and sacred Nature, the whole land - not just shrines - comes to be seen as holy

58. Which best shows geography, culture and spirituality fusing together (a 'punyakshetra')?

- (A) a coin minted to show a king's power
- (B) a riverbank or forest revered as holy, where pilgrims gather and Nature is protected
- (C) a tax-free land grant on a copper plate
- (D) a court poet's praise-inscription

59. Which pairing of network and number is correct?

- (A) the jyotirlingas number 12 and the Shakti pithas number 51
- (B) the jyotirlingas number 51 and the Shakti pithas number 12
- (C) the char dham number 12 and the jyotirlingas number 4
- (D) the Shakti pithas number 4 and the char dham number 51

60. A student writes: 'In India, you don't only visit the sacred - you can travel through a sacred land.' The best support from the chapter is:

- (A) networks of holy sites and revered rivers, mountains and forests turn the whole territory into a sacred geography
- (B) there is exactly one holy building in the country
- (C) sacredness ends at a temple's walls
- (D) only foreigners find India's land holy

Solutions — Social Science (Class 7), Chapter 8: How the Land Becomes Sacred

Marking: +4 correct, –1 wrong, 0 unattempted. Maximum marks **240**.

Answer Key

Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans
1	D	11	C	21	A	31	C	41	D	51	B
2	D	12	B	22	D	32	C	42	D	52	A
3	B	13	C	23	C	33	D	43	B	53	D
4	D	14	C	24	B	34	B	44	C	54	C
5	C	15	D	25	A	35	B	45	A	55	A
6	A	16	C	26	B	36	A	46	B	56	A
7	D	17	B	27	A	37	A	47	C	57	D
8	D	18	B	28	D	38	B	48	A	58	B
9	C	19	A	29	B	39	A	49	C	59	A
10	D	20	B	30	D	40	C	50	C	60	A

Answer-key distribution: A = 15, B = 15, C = 15, D = 15.

Worked Solutions

- (D)** Sacredness means deep religious or spiritual significance - holy, divine and worthy of reverence. Age, ownership and size do not by themselves make something sacred.
- (D)** In India sacredness reaches far beyond buildings - a pilgrimage, a river, a mountain, a grove or the land itself can be holy, creating a 'sacred geography'. It is not confined to buildings, one religion, or cities.
- (B)** 'Sacred geography' means sacred sites are scattered across the whole land, making the territory itself sacred. It is not about a single mountain, temple schooling, or missing maps.
- (D)** A pilgrimage is a journey to a sacred site. It is not a tax, a market, or a coronation.
- (C)** Tirtha literally means a river-crossing place; symbolically it is where one crosses from ordinary life to a higher, spiritual one. The peak, pot and grove are other sacred things in the chapter.

- 6. (A)** The river-crossing root captures the idea of a tirtha as a crossing-point from the ordinary to the spiritual. It does not mean sites are underwater, that rivers were unholy (they were deeply revered), or that crossing was banned.
- 7. (D)** A shrine is holy through links to the divine, a relic, or a spiritual figure. A battlefield, market or palace is not, by itself, a shrine.
- 8. (D)** A relic is a venerated remain or belonging of a saint or spiritual figure. The calendar era is a samvat, the land grant an agrahara, and the river-meeting a sangam.
- 9. (C)** Faiths born in India (Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism, Sikhism) and those from outside (Islam, Christianity, Judaism, Zoroastrianism) all mark sacred places here. It is not limited to one religion or to either group alone.
- 10. (D)** Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism and Sikhism arose in India. Islam, Christianity, Judaism and Zoroastrianism came from outside; the other lists mix the two groups.
- 11. (C)** Sufi dargahs, and natural sites like rivers and mountains, are revered across faiths, so India's sacred geography is often shared, not split neatly by religion.
- 12. (B)** Many of India's holy places - dargahs, rivers, mountains, groves - are shared across communities, so the 'one religion only' idea is wrong. Sharing is common, and the sites genuinely are sacred.
- 13. (C)** India's natural sacred places are revered across many faiths and communities. Their sacredness rests on shared belief, not foreign residence, government declaration, or a yearly limit.
- 14. (C)** Pilgrimage is presented as an ancient and continuous Indian tradition stretching back millennia - not modern, one-off, or borrowed from Europe.
- 15. (D)** The hard climb to a hilltop shrine is seen as mirroring the pilgrim's inner spiritual journey. It is not meaningless, a sign of divine dislike, or meant to bar pilgrims.
- 16. (C)** The outer hardship mirrors inner growth, giving the journey its meaning. It is not a strength contest, a shortcut (it is the opposite), and it brings the pilgrim closer to Nature, not away from it.
- 17. (B)** A Tirthankara is a supreme Jain teacher of dharma, literally 'one who makes a tirtha', guiding the crossing to a higher life. The river-meeting is a sangam, the grant an agrahara, and the fig tree a peepal or banyan.
- 18. (B)** Jain sacred tirthas are tied to the Tirthankaras. The jyotirlingas are Shaiva, the Shakti pithas relate to the goddess, and the Kumbh is a riverbank fair - none of them Jain teacher-sites.

- 19. (A)** Both words share the 'crossing' idea, central to Indian notions of the sacred. It is not about payment, war, or tower-building.
- 20. (B)** The char dham - Badrinath (north), Dwarka (west), Puri (east) and Rameswaram (south) - ring the whole country. They are not in one valley, abroad, or in a single city.
- 21. (A)** The char dham are Badrinath, Dwarka, Puri and Rameswaram. Haridwar, Prayagraj, Nashik and Ujjain are the Kumbh cities; the other lists mix in unrelated sites.
- 22. (D)** There are 12 jyotirlingas, each a shrine to Shiva. The 51 sites are the Shakti pithas (the goddess), and the other options are invented.
- 23. (C)** The 51 Shakti pithas mark where, by tradition, parts of the divine mother Sati fell, covering the subcontinent. They are not Buddhist sermon-sites, the char dham, or Kumbh grounds.
- 24. (B)** Networks of sites stretching across the land knit distant regions into a single sacred geography. They did not isolate regions, confine worship to one city, or end pilgrimage - they encouraged it.
- 25. (A)** Networks like the char dham, jyotirlingas and Shakti pithas connected the whole land through pilgrimage. They were not kingdom-border markers, royal-only sites, or river replacements.
- 26. (B)** Shared sacred sites and pilgrimage routes helped bind India's diverse languages and customs into one civilisation over millennia. They did not cause permanent war, erase local customs, or block travel - they promoted it.
- 27. (A)** Pilgrims journeying among distant sites spread ideas and customs, integrating the subcontinent. It did not impose one language, seal regions off, or abolish kingdoms.
- 28. (D)** Sacred geography is presented as a long-term unifying force across a diverse land. It was not chiefly divisive, trader-only, or modern.
- 29. (B)** The same roads often carried pilgrims and traders together; pilgrims needed goods and some traders were pilgrims too. Trade was not banned at sites, pilgrims did buy goods, and the routes overlapped.
- 30. (D)** Crowds of pilgrims created demand for food, supplies and lodging, drawing traders to the same routes. Pilgrims were not barred from money, sites did not pay traders off, and trade was not illegal.
- 31. (C)** Shared routes show religion and the economy intertwined in everyday travel. They were not separate, travel was not royal-only, and rivers were crossing-points, not barriers.

- 32. (C)** A sangam is a river confluence, regarded as a specially sacred crossing-place. The hilltop shrine, the tree and the four-site network are different features.
- 33. (D)** River and confluence worship goes back to Vedic times. It is not a recent, post-Gupta, or city-only practice.
- 34. (B)** A sangam is a powerful 'crossing place', matching the tirtha idea of moving to a higher life. The waters do not stop, bathing is central (not banned), and it is not a tax border.
- 35. (B)** The Kumbh Mela is a huge riverbank pilgrimage-fair timed by a sacred calendar. It is not a hilltop shrine, a land grant, or a Jain teacher.
- 36. (A)** Kumbh ('pot') + mela ('fair'), recalling the pot of amrita. The other pairings are unrelated to the name.
- 37. (A)** The Kumbh rotates among four riverbank cities - Haridwar, Prayagraj, Nashik and Ujjain. Those other four 'abodes' are the char dham, not the Kumbh sites; and it is neither fixed to one city nor held abroad.
- 38. (B)** The Kumbh's location and timing follow the positions of Jupiter and the Sun over a roughly 12-year cycle. It is not set by royal vote, the monsoon, or temple-building.
- 39. (A)** The Kumbh moves among four cities on a roughly 12-year cycle set by the sky, so 'same place every year' is false. It is not in a new country yearly, a once-a-millennium event, or non-existent.
- 40. (C)** Sacred mountains are seen as gateways to heaven. They are approached by pilgrims (not forbidden), are not the only sacred places, and are not trader-homes.
- 41. (D)** Holding the landscape sacred encourages people to protect Nature. The worldview does not devalue Nature, bar all access, or prize only buildings.
- 42. (D)** Sacred mountains show geography, culture and spirituality fused - the heart of 'sacred geography'. They are not kept apart, limited to flat land, or dismissed as worthless.
- 43. (B)** The peepal is a sacred fig (*Ficus religiosa*) revered across faiths. The river-meeting is a sangam, the shrine a tirtha, and the pot the Kumbh's amrita symbol.
- 44. (C)** The Buddha's Bodhi tree was a peepal (bodhi means 'awakening'). It was not a banyan or mango, and a sangam is a river confluence, not a tree.
- 45. (A)** 'Banyan' comes from the banias (traders) who met in its shade. The name is not from kings, rivers, or Tirthankaras.

- 46. (B)** The banyan's hanging roots reach the ground and become new trunks, spreading the tree widely. The golden leaves, stone trunk and Kumbh-only flowers are inventions.
- 47. (C)** By tying many places to their heroes' journeys, the epics help spread sacredness across the land. They do not ban pilgrimage, name only one site, or ignore places.
- 48. (A)** A sacred grove is a community-protected natural forest seen as a deity's abode. It is not a taxed royal garden, a market, or a sangam.
- 49. (C)** Because the grove is a deity's abode, harming it through hunting, felling or mining is forbidden. Such acts are not encouraged, required, or trader-only.
- 50. (C)** It is belief - that the grove is a god's home - that has shielded sacred groves, often without any formal law. They are not chiefly protected by laws, walls, or royal payments.
- 51. (B)** Belief has preserved the groves' biodiversity and water for centuries without formal law - a powerful conservation force. It is not purely harmful, police-dependent, or limited to buildings.
- 52. (A)** Sacred groves are protected mainly by belief, not by formal laws, so the statement is largely wrong. Belief is central, the groves are protected, and they certainly exist.
- 53. (D)** Sacred geography appears in other parts of the world as well, though the chapter focuses on India. It is not India-only, modern-European, or desert-only.
- 54. (C)** Conservation (Latin conservare, 'to keep, preserve') is safeguarding Nature and heritage for the future. It is the opposite of clear-cutting, building over rivers, or discarding traditions.
- 55. (A)** Seeing Nature as sacred motivates its protection - a lesson for modern conservation. It does not devalue Nature, encourage mining, or imply Nature is indestructible.
- 56. (A)** Sacred places are presented as a shared natural-and-cultural heritage we must protect. They are not useless, trader-owned, or valued only for tourism.
- 57. (D)** Sacredness spreads through pilgrimage, site-networks and sacred Nature until the land itself is holy - a sacred geography. It is not one temple, royal declaration, or geography-free.
- 58. (B)** A punyakshetra is a natural landscape seen as sacred - geography, culture and spirituality fused. The coin, the agrahara grant and the prashasti are administrative or political items, not sacred landscapes.
- 59. (A)** There are 12 jyotirlingas, 51 Shakti pithas and 4 char dham. The distractors swap these counts.

60. (A) Networks of sites plus sacred rivers, mountains and forests make the entire land sacred - exactly a 'sacred geography' one travels through. The other options shrink sacredness to a single building, a temple's walls, or foreigners' eyes.